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Class 1: Social Movements

Introduction and the development of social movements

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

Agenda for the day

- Poll: course introduction
- Course Introduction
- Quick intro to concepts
- Onto our topic: social movements
- Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

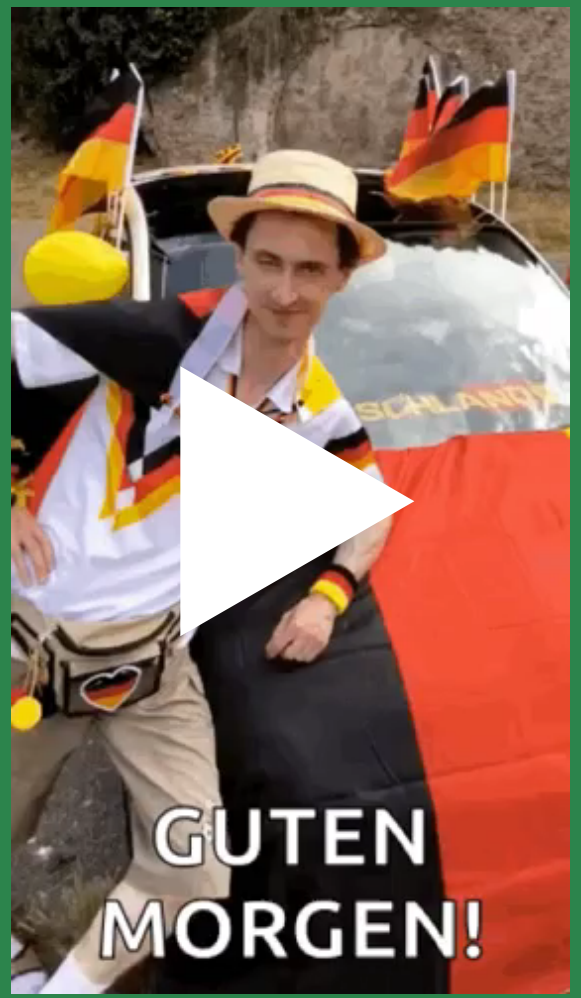
Poll: course introduction

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Course Introduction

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- What are ‘social movements’?
- How this course relates to Prof. Bolleyer’s lecture
- Course structure
- Learning aims
- Course assessments
- Office hours and communication
- Course website
- Q & A
- student introductions



First...

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Can you understand me?

- Lots of different languages represented in the room → but please don't be shy: feel empowered to participate, even if you are not so confident in your English skills
  - when you speak, please speak up (*I'm rapidly ageing and my hearing is not what it once was*)

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Read the syllabus!

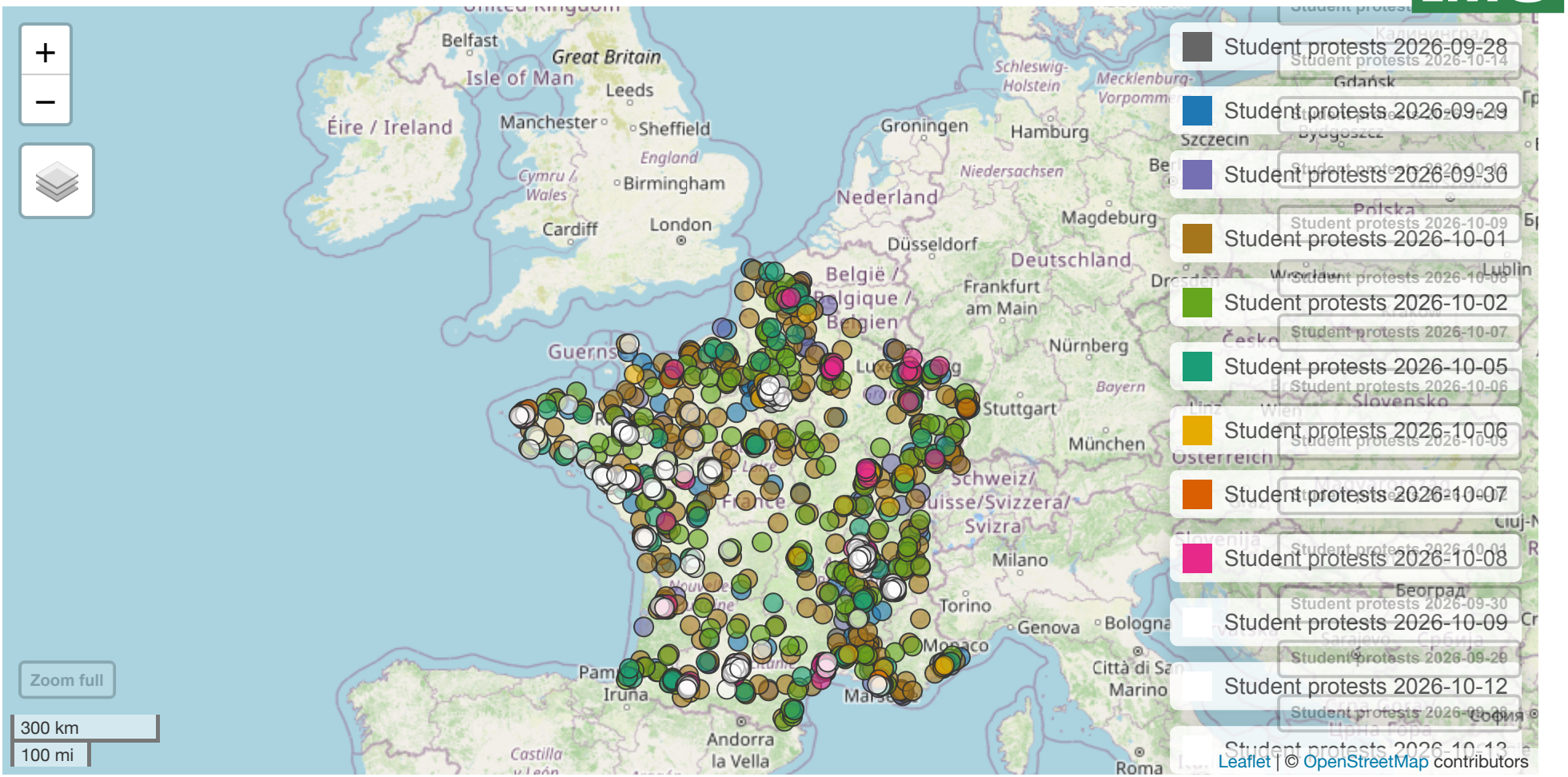
- We have a shiny (continually developing) website for the course
  - https://michaelzeller.de/course-sm/
- Before our next meeting, your task is to peruse the website
  - especially the Syllabus and Readings pages.

Defining social movements

- Broadly: *collections of people that mobilise, coordinate, and campaign for some objective*
  - We will focus on movements with *socio-political objectives*

- What are some examples that you know (now or historically)?

A current example - French student protests



protests through 8 October 2026

Connection to Prof. Bolleyer's lecture

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- This course is one of the Grundkurse for Prof. Bolleyer's **Einführung in das politische System Deutschlands**
- This course is a detailed investigation of a related topic—not a tutorial on the material in Prof. Bolleyer's lecture
  - So—as should go without saying—for both the lecture and GK: read and attend classes

Structure of the course

Date	Class	Lecture
2026-10-12	1	Introduction and the development of social movements (SMs)
2026-10-19	2	SM theories: collective behaviour, resource mobilisation, political processes
2026-10-26	3	SM theories: framing, civil society
2026-11-02	4	Mobilisation, recruitment, participation
2026-11-09	5	Collective identity and emotions
2026-11-16	6	Organisation, strategies and tactics
2026-11-23	7	SMs and the media
2026-11-30	8	SM coalitions
2026-12-07	9	State responses
2026-12-14	10	Counter-mobilisation and countermovements
2026-12-21	11	SMs online
2027-01-11	12	SM impact
2027-01-18	13	Demobilisation
2027-01-25	14	Contemporary social movements and beyond: climate, migration
2027-02-01	15	NO CLASS MEETING TODAY

Coverage of cases within and outside Germany

- Social movements are numerous and varied
- In this course, we will consider some of the most influential/most studied movements (NB: U.S. bias in research)
- As often as possible, we will refer to a set of movements (organisations) active in Germany
  - several to be introduced next week
  - in Week 3, you will be assigned a case to study in depth
    - all of the cases were/are active in Germany

Aims

- acquire **substantive knowledge** of aspects of social movements (theory, cases) and manifestation within Germany and elsewhere
- enhance **critical knowledge** to evaluate research thereof
- gain familiarity with **methodological approaches** to studying social movements
- (further) develop the capacity to…
  - assess episodes and broader cycles of movement activity, especially by identifying underlying factors and comparing across contexts
  - critically evaluate reporting and research on social movements, especially by evaluating the data and methods used

Assessment: related to BRD lecture

Studiengang	*Belegung*	*Leistungsnachweis(e)*	*Klausurinhalte*
BA Hauptfach	*VL (Vorlesung BRD) und GK (Grundkurs)*	*Klausur (90 Min.)*	*3/5 Wissensfragen und 1/3 Essayfrage*
BA Nebenfach 60 ECTS	*VL und GK*	*Klausur (90 Min.)*	*3/5 Wissensfragen und 1/3 Essayfrage*
Lehramt Unterrichtsfach	VL und GK	Klausur (90 Min.) & Referat	3/5 Wissensfragen und 1/3 Essayfrage
BA Nebenfach 30 ECTS	nur VL	Klausur (90 Min.)	3/5 Wissensfragen kein Essay
Lehramt Didaktikfach	nur VL	Klausur (60 Min.)	2/5 Wissensfragen kein Essay
Austauschstudierende für VL	*VL*	*Klausur (90 Min.)*	*3/5 Wissensfragen kein Essay*
Austauschstudierende für GK	GK	Festgelegt durch GK Dozent	N/A

Die Sprache der Essayfragen (Deutsch oder Englisch) richtet sich nach der Sprache des jeweiligen GKs. Unabhängig von der Sprache

der Fragestellung (oder Teil der Veranstaltung) können Studierende je nach Präferenz auf Deutsch oder Englisch antworten.

Kontakt für prüfungsrechtliche Fragen, Kursanmeldung, - wechsel, -abmeldung, Fragen zur Anmeldung zur Prüfung:
studienbuero@gsi.uni-muenchen.de

Assessment: within this course

	Participation	Presentation	Essay	Klausur
BA Hauptfach	X			X
BA Nebenfach (60 ECTS)	X			X
Lehramt Unterrichtsfach	X	X		X
BA Nebenfach (30 ECTS)	X			X (nur VL)
Lehramt Didaktikfach	X			X (nur VL, 60 Min., 2 Wissensfragen)
Austauschstudierende für VL	X			X (nur VL)
Austauschstudierende für GK	X	X	X	

Course assessment - *Participation*

- No examination in this course, BUT there is in '*Einführung Politisches System der BRD*'. There, you respond to an essay question from this course.
  - Exam on 1 February (Monday) at 14.00 in the AudiMax
  - 90-minutes written exam: response to 3 of 5 short-answer prompts from Prof. Bolleyer's lecture and to 1 of 3 essay prompts from this course
  - can bring a translation dictionary (e.g., German-Ukrainian)
    - be certain it has no notes inside!
  - Exam registration in December—careful not to miss it
- read, develop knowledge of assigned social movement, attend class and actively participate

Course assessment - *Presentation*

- **Presentation**
  - short (max. 20 minutes) group (2-4 students) talk on a method for studying social movements
  - A *method* is a system of data collection and analysis
    1. introduce method,
    2. explain its utility for studying social movements,
    3. [the crucial part] and *discuss one applied example*

- recipe for success: search for a journal article on a topic of interest to you and select your *method* on that basis

Essay (*Hausarbeit*): Data report

- data report on a social movement phenomenon (e.g., protests events, violence, framing, news coverage)
  - why a dataset? Helpful preparation for thinking about validity, reliability, etc. → relevant for quant. and qual.
- gather and present data, generate analytical insights
- 2000-3000 words (excluding citations)
- 2027-01-15: short synopsis due. 2027-03-05: full, final report due.
- consider working with data visualisation and analysis software
  - but not required! Students have aced essay with Excel/Word
- A rule: **no data from or use of Statista or data curation services.**

submit all assignments by email: m.zeller@lmu.de

For the paper, and writing in general...

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Table III. A semiotic checklist

1. This is what I am focusing on
2. This is why it is relevant
3. This is what is known/not known (and why it needs attention)
4. This is my burning question
5. This is how I aim to address the question (theoretically/empirically)
6. This is what I did
7. This is what I found
8. This is what it means
9. This is what I add
10. This is why you should care

Patriotta, G. (2017). Crafting papers for publication: Novelty and convention in academic writing. *Journal of Management Studies, 54*(5), 747-759.

Further: tools of the research trade...

- qualitative data management: e.g., MAXQDA, ATLAS.ti
- quantitative (and qual.) data analysis software: e.g., R (and R Studio), Stata
- typesetting programmes: LaTeX (through TexStudio) and RMarkdown

Elements of a typical class meeting

- Opening question(s)/discussion point(s)
  - e.g., theoretical dilemma, typology forming, news item
- Summarising lecture on theory/findings related to week's topic
- A live poll: general questions and about your group
  - questions about groups shown on last slide of preceding week
- Short video relevant to topic
- Discussing the reading(s), highlighting important points
- Student presentation(s)
- Open data for you to explore
- Summative discussion: takeaways, new ideas, lingering questions

Throughout, we will use *cases* to link *theory* to *real-world events*

Cases for students

- to be assigned in Week 3





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711

Stuttgart

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Open data - on slides coloured like this

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- data from published research and ongoing projects
  - available for download (in slides or from external website)
- interactive visualisations
  - scalable line/bar plots
  - network graphs
  - maps
- a chance to explore data related to a topic
  - recognised patterns and *describe* the world of social movements
  - opportunity to go further, if it interests you

Blessed with too much material

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- most classes are overfull with videos, research snapshots, poll questions, etc.
  - this is a *seminar*
    - ***discussion*** is the priority
  - makes it even more important to do required reading, review any slides that we cannot cover in class
- in extreme case (lots of material uncovered) I will upload a video to the course website

Classroom air quality

- in an earlier term, a student with respiratory issues took CO2 readings in classes with closed and then slightly open window…





closed window

slightly open window

since lower indoor C02 improves cognition… we will air before class and (unless it is way too cold) at least tilt a window during class

In case class cannot meet...

- If it is not possible to convene in-person,
  - you will receive an email:

1. the class will meet online via Zoom (link in email), or
2. the class will be cancelled, a recorded lecture uploaded on the 'Slides' page of the website, and a short review at the start of the next meeting
   - 7 December (Class 9) will be cancelled and replaced with a recorded lecture

Colour scheme for course slides

- Why? To make concepts and important points easier to identify and review

- concepts (dark red) - building blocks of social science, important elements in every class session
- discussion point (indigo) - a question or prompt to discuss as a class (essential component of a *seminar*)
- finding (dark orange) - a noteworthy finding from one or more studies
- methods point (blue) - element of research design or methodology
- important point (red) - something particularly noteworthy

Office hours and communication

- best to send an email
  - michael.zeller@gsi.uni-muenchen.de
  - m.zeller@lmu.de
- 11.00 - 12.00 on Wednesdays at GSI (Oettingenstr. 67) - Room H105
- or by appointment
- Please use your LMU email address for communication
  - this is important for the security of the university email system

Course website

- no use of Moodle
- a purpose-built website: https://michaelzeller.de/course-sm/
  - all readings available
  - slides available before class
    - PDF copies may omit some parts of HTML slides (e.g., animations, data visualisations)—but those HTML copies will always be available for you too
  - (if necessary) video lectures
  - example data report
  - some resources

Resources

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journals and data | books

About me

- tell me if you have problems understanding me
  - there's an accent at work that I tragically cannot shake off
- Ph.D. in political science from Central European University (CEU)
  - specialisation in qualitative methods (QCA, [Bayesian] process tracing), but also quant. text analysis, network analysis
- researcher in funded projects on …
  - violent/banned far-right groups and online content moderation
  - radicalisation, violent extremism, polarisation, and resilience
- current work: militant democracy; far-right activist networks; political violence (in 1970s Northern Ireland; in contemporary Italy); paths to female leadership in Asia; protest and polarisation

About the course

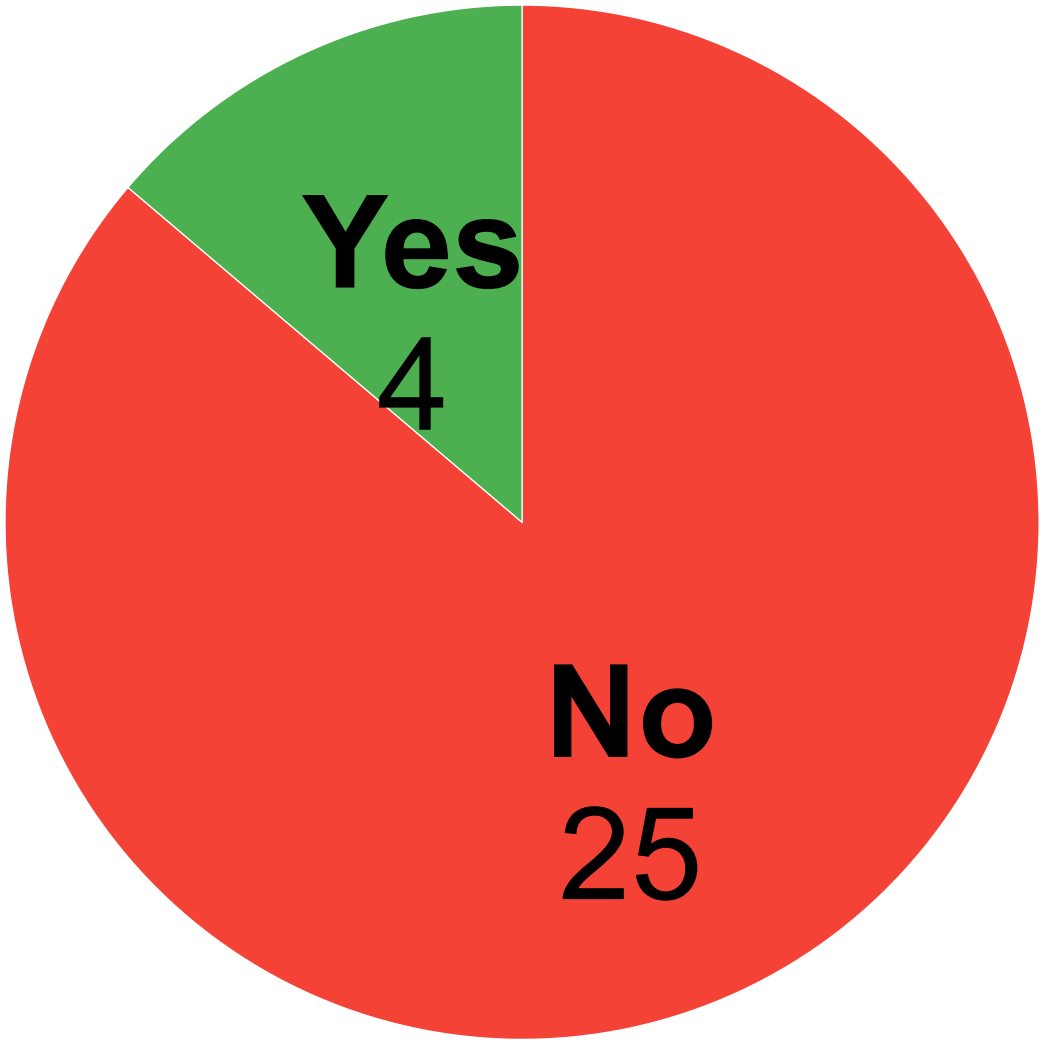
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Q & A

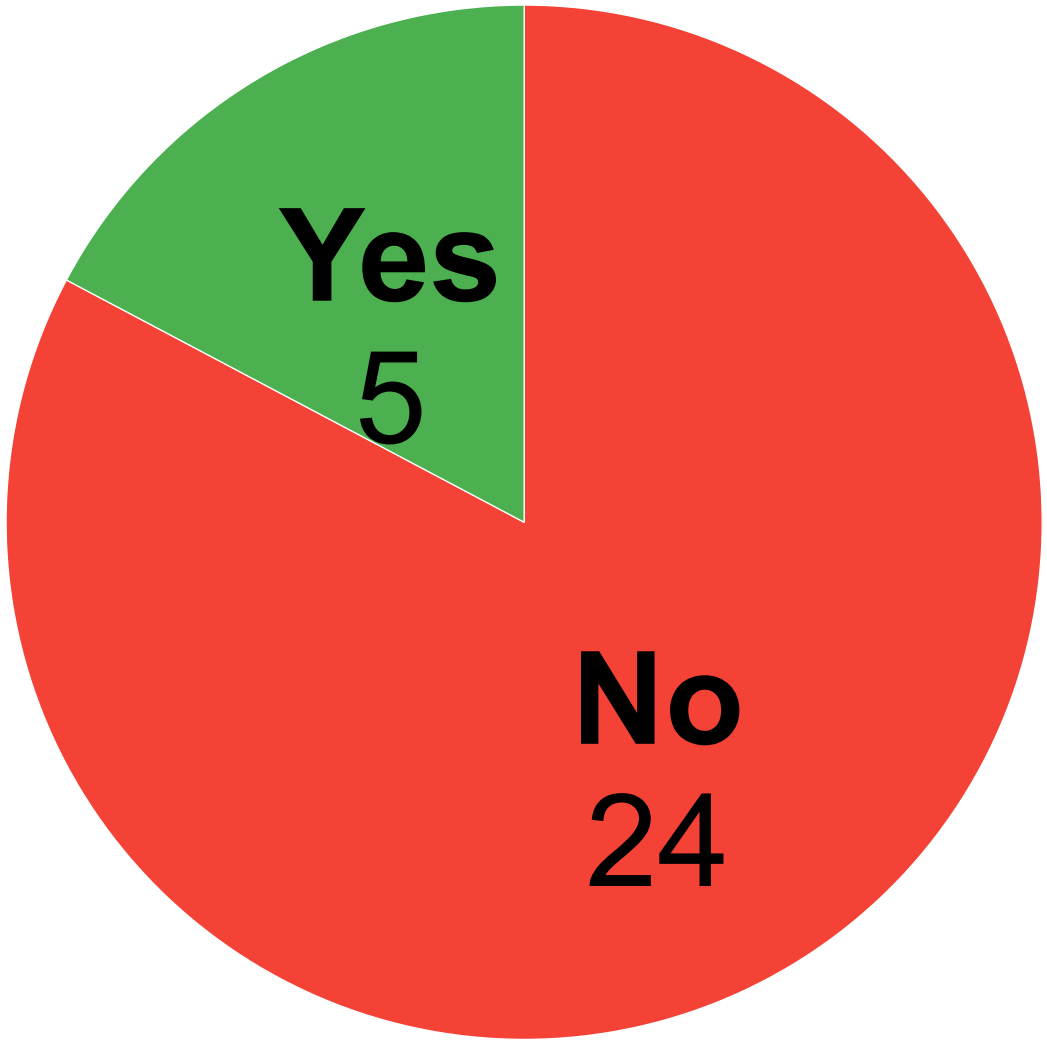
About you! Poll results (Respondents: 29)

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Prior methods class

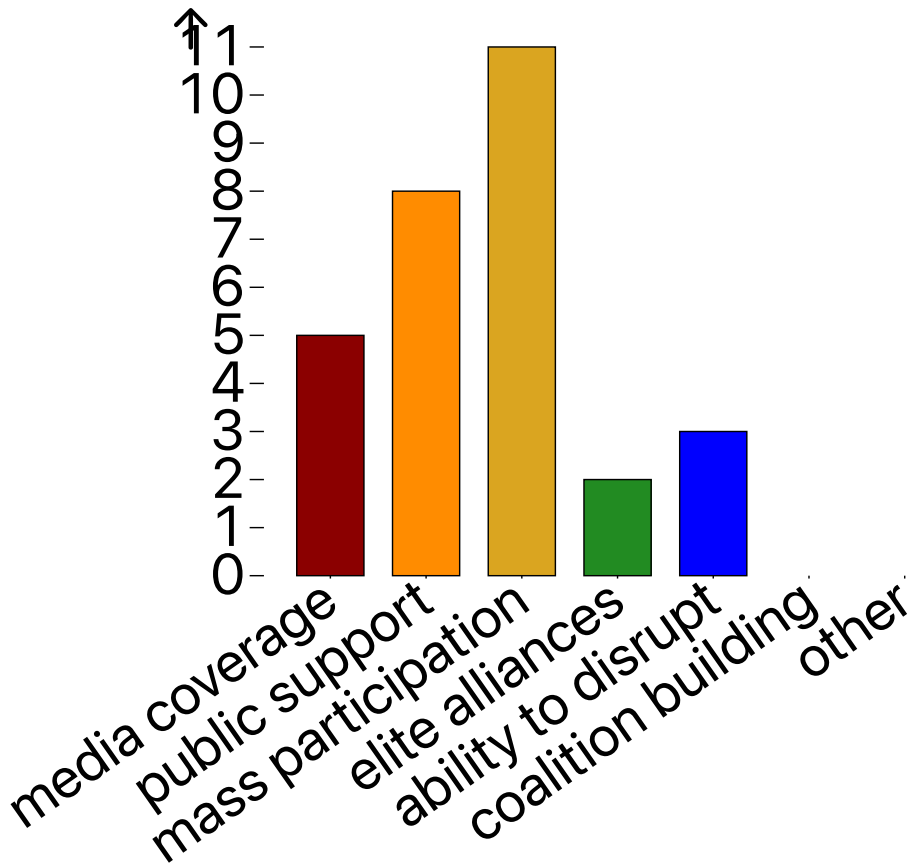


Prior analytical software use



About you! Poll results

Most influential in success of a social movement?



About you! Poll results

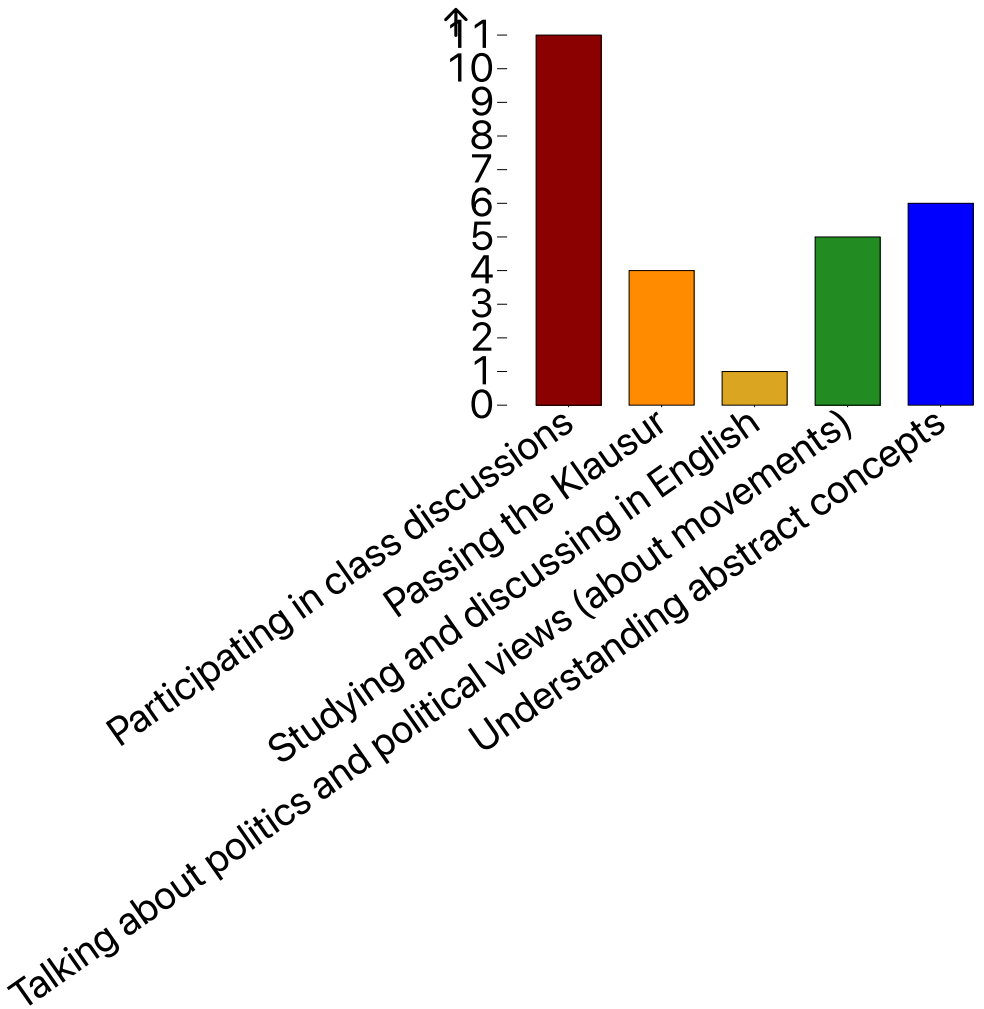
Any particular politically violent group you want to learn more about?

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▸Array(11) ["FFF", "Fridays for Future ", "Feminist Movement ", "Fridays for Future ", "Revolutionary and reactionary social movements", "DSA movement in the US", "Rise of the far right. Rise of national socialism in the 20s/30s", "#Metoo movement, BLM", "animal rights movement", "Amnesty International", "AIDS Crisis & Queer rights movement"]
```

About you! Student introductions

- Information about you, possibly including…
  - Expectations for this course
  - favourite joke
  - Study programme
  - favourite song
  - Country (place) of origin
  - top source for news
  - Background in education/research
  - secret skill
  - Academic/professional aspirations

About you! Poll results: biggest concern



Quick intro to concepts

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- concept formation (cf. Adcock and Collier 2001)
- types of concepts



Concept formation

- **concepts** are the building blocks of social science research
  - a term denoting an abstract idea

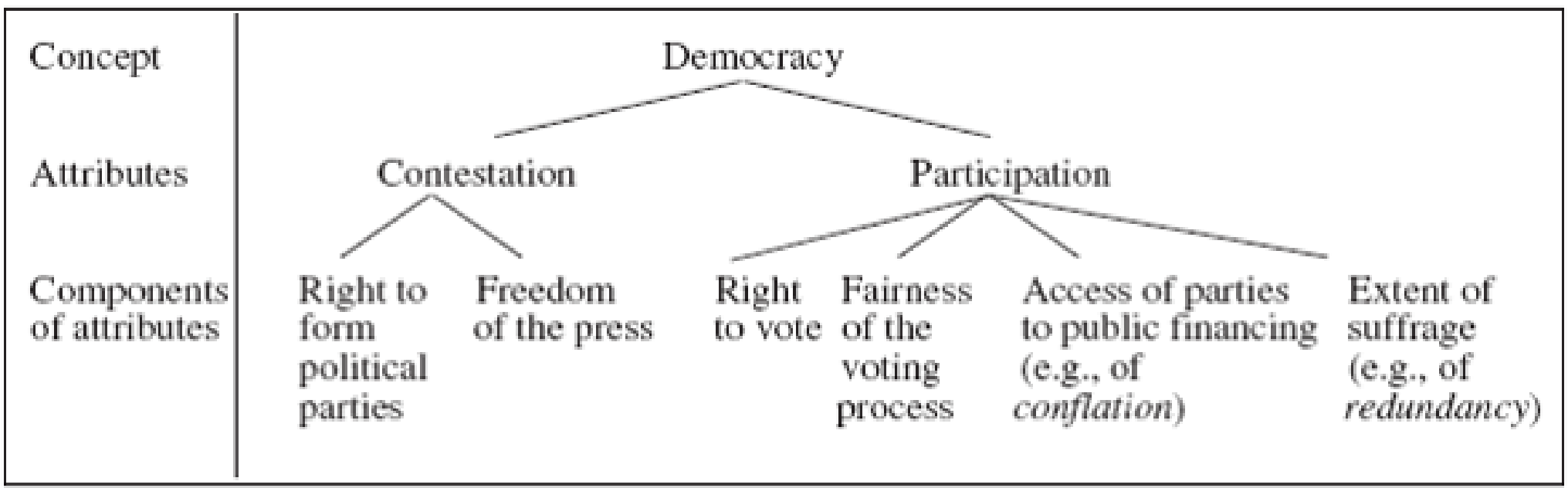


Figure 1. **The logical structure of concepts.**

Concept formation

- identifying bounds of concepts
  - See Sartori (1970)
- broadly, three types of concepts in social science

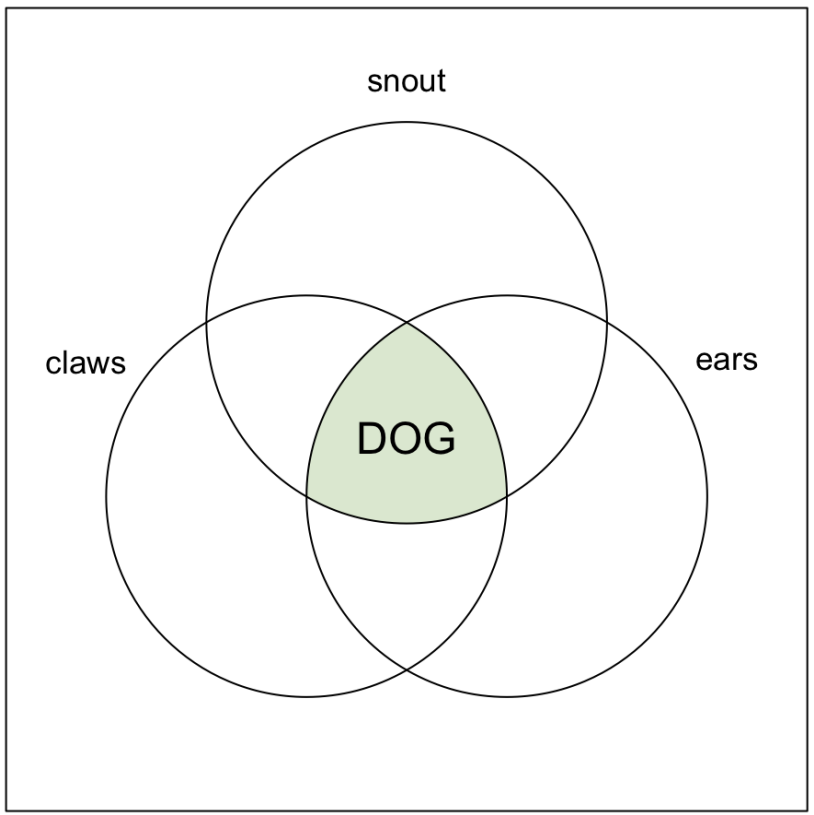
1. classical: **all** criteria are shared by **all** cases

2. radial: **some** criteria are shared by **all** cases; others are not

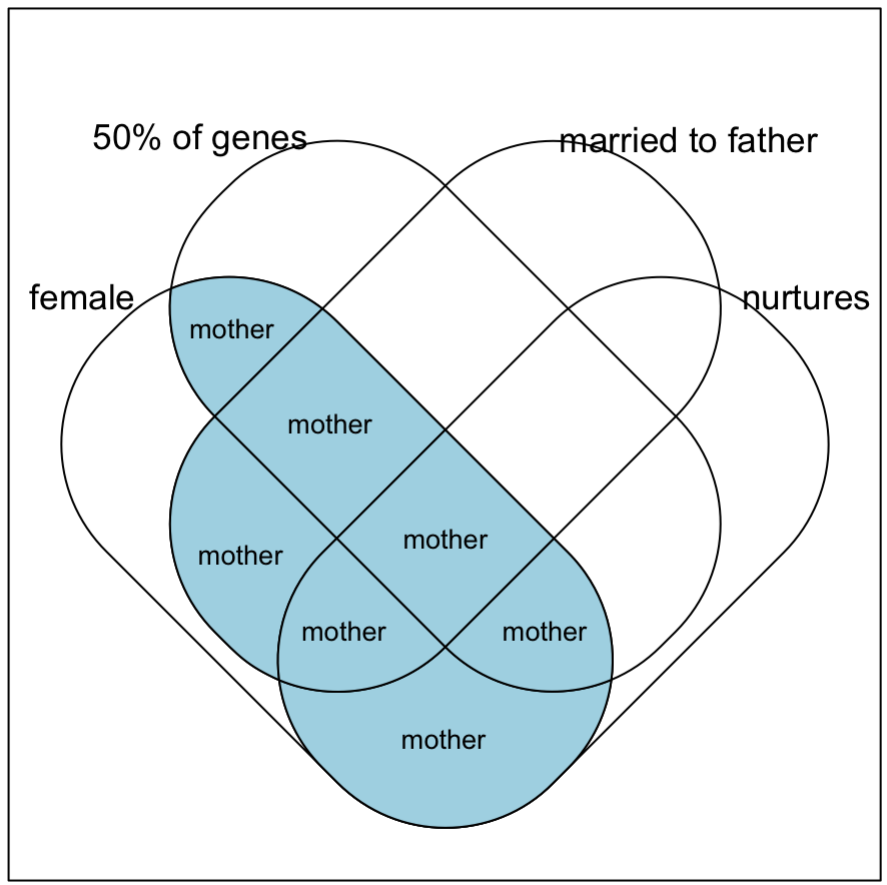
3. family resemblance: **No** criterion is shared by **all** cases

Visualising classical/radial concepts

Classical concept (all criteria)



Radial concept (all share ‘female’)



Family resemblance: no criterion shared by all (e.g., games)

Classical vs. radial (Collier and Mahon 1993)

FIGURE 4

Differentiation of Classical and Radial Categories

Classical Category: Dog

	Category	Components				
Primary Category	Dog	A	B	C		
Secondary Categories	Retriever	A	B	C	D	
	Sheepdog	A	B	C		E
	Spaniel	A	B	C		F

Note: Differentiating characteristics of secondary categories are *in addition to* those of the primary category.

A, B, and C = Hypothetical set of general attributes of dogs
D, E, and F = Hypothetical attributes that differentiate specific types of dogs

Radial Category: Mother

	Category	Components				
Primary Category	Mother	A	B	C	D	E
Secondary Categories	Genetic mother	A	B			
	Birth mother	A		C		
	Nurturing mother	A			D	
	Stepmother	A				E

Note: Differentiating characteristics of secondary categories are *contained within* the primary category.

A = Female
B = Provides 50% of genetic makeup
C = Gives birth to child
D = Provides nurturance
E = Married to father

Onto our topic: social movements

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- conceptual framework
  - key definitions
- prelude to next two meetings
- social movements in *contention*



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Tarrow (2011) - conceptual framework

> Contentious politics is triggered when changing political opportunities and constraints create incentives to take action for actors who lack resources on their own. People contend through known repertoires of contention and expand them by creating innovations at their margins. When backed by well-structured social networks and galvanized by culturally resonant, action-oriented symbols, contentious politics leads to sustained interaction with opponents – to social movements.

Tarrow (2011) - key definitions

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

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COLLECTIVE
ACTION

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

includes *social movements*

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

includes *social movements*

- respond to threats

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

includes *social movements*

- exploit opportunities
- respond to threats

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

includes *social movements*

- socialise and mobilise constituencies
- exploit opportunities
- respond to threats

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

includes *social movements*

- build organisations, resources
- socialise and mobilise constituencies
- exploit opportunities
- respond to threats

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

Contentious collective action

↓

includes *social movements*

- advance frames (ideologies)
- build organisations, resources
- socialise and mobilise constituencies
- exploit opportunities
- respond to threats

Situating movements, Tarrow (2011) concepts

COLLECTIVE ACTION

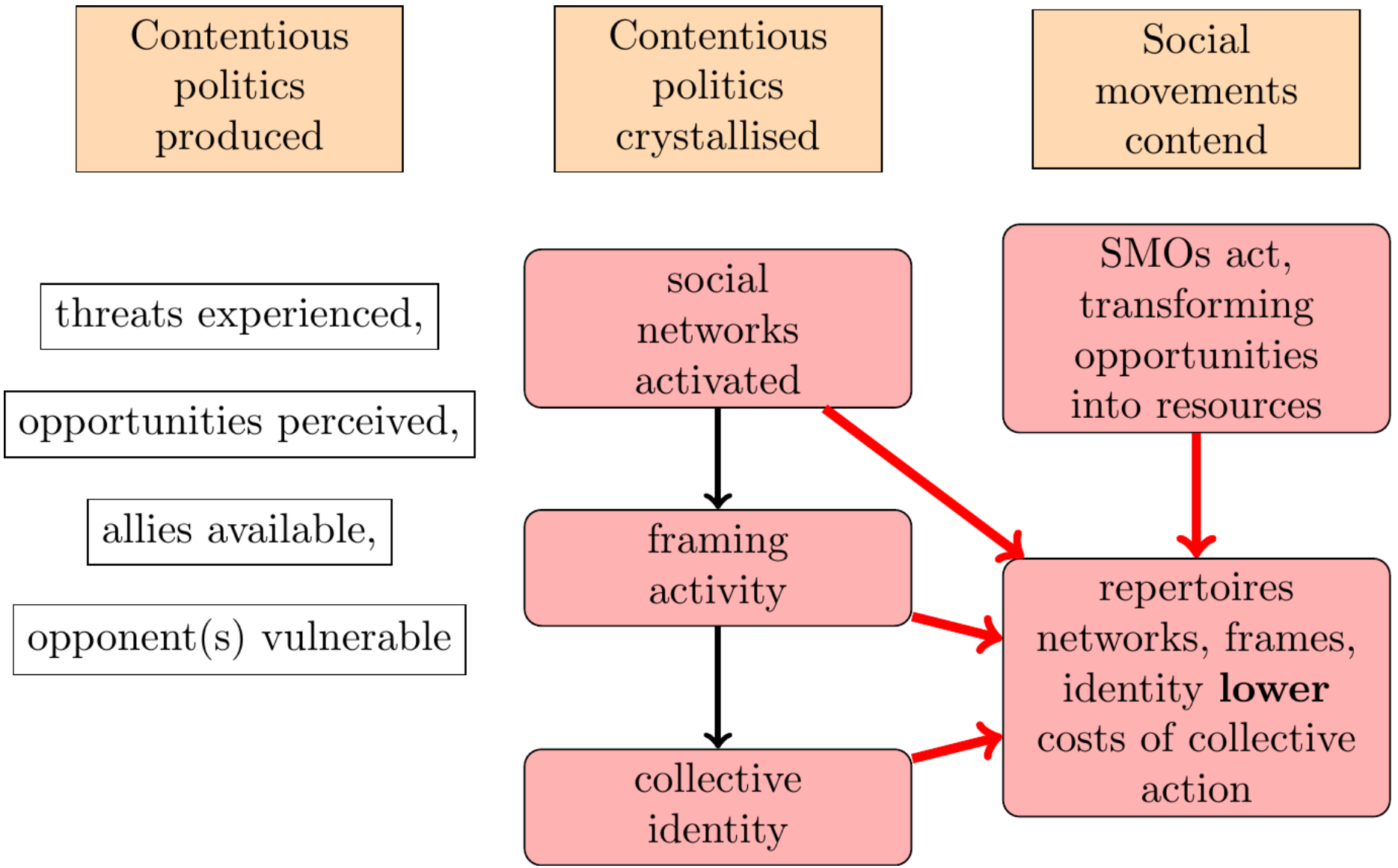
Contentious collective action → Contentious politics

↓

includes *social movements*

- advance frames (ideologies)
- build organisations, resources
- socialise and mobilise constituencies
- exploit opportunities
- respond to threats

Social movements in contention (Tarrow 2011, 33)



Tarrow (2011), prelude to next two meetings

Parent Scholarship	Social Movement Studies (SMS)
Marx and Engels, class conflict	Collective behaviour theory
structuralist (leaves little room for the mechanisms that actually draw individuals in collective action)	(grievances, [relative] deprivation)
legacy for SMS: class forces and other cleavages spurring collective action	
Lenin and resource mobilisation	Resource mobilisation theory
vanguardism	
legacy for SMS: focus on leaders/organisers (mobilising interests) and organisations	leadership, organisations, and various resources
Gramsci and cultural hegemony	Framing and Collective identity theories
counterculture of working class can overcome bourgeois hegemonic culture	'cultural turn' (from anthropology, sociology)
legacy for SMS: constructivism, prefiguration, and movement impact on culture	forming consensus in movements
Tilly's Polity Model	Political process theory
the structure of the state/polity	opportunities, constraints, and the structure of contentious politics
legacy for SMS: repertoires of contention, WUNC (worthiness, unity,	

Examples of social movements?

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What cases are you familiar with?

What do you know about them?

How can we categorise them?

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Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here: https://forms.gle/AjHt6fcnwZxkSg4X8

Alternatively, please send me an email: m.zeller@lmu.de

References

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